

Consent

Consent is an important part of any healthy sexual relationship. It means that at a certain time, someone agrees that they want to engage in a specific type of foreplay or sex. Consent is only given if the person wants to give it and is able to give it.

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◀ 200–201 Unhealthy relationships

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What counts as consent

In order for consent to be given, the person consenting must agree by choice, and have the freedom and capacity to make that choice. It may take some time for both partners to feel ready, and that should be respected. When both people consent to a sexual activity, it makes for a safe and satisfying experience, and helps to build a healthy relationship.



▷ No pressure

Consent is about choosing of your own free will, without any pressure.

TEEN HINTS

Being respectful

Whether you're beginning a sexual relationship with a new boyfriend or girlfriend or you're in a long-term sexual relationship already, it's important to discuss what you both enjoy and what you're happy with. Discussing what you want from sex or what feels good to you is healthy and respectful. Don't ever make your partner feel ashamed. Criticizing, body shaming, or making them feel self-conscious is disrespectful.

You should always check to make sure the other person is definitely happy having sex. If they don't want to have foreplay or sex, reassure them that that is completely fine and that you are still interested in them.

Asking for consent

It's important when checking for consent not to pressure a boyfriend or girlfriend into saying "yes." Even if they have consented to sex before, they may feel uncomfortable this time or in this situation. Be careful not to make them feel like they have to do anything—for example, don't start a sexual behavior before the other person has consented.

The easiest and surest way of asking for consent is to ask out loud if they are happy and comfortable with what's happening or about to happen. This eliminates any uncertainty, misinterpretation, or pressure. It also makes it easier for the partner to say "no" if they want to.



▷ Being clear

Asking respectfully if the other person consents is the best way to make sure both people feel comfortable and ready.

Giving consent

Sometimes consent can be communicated by encouraging words and noises during foreplay. But talking is the best way to give consent. Trusting a boyfriend or girlfriend means that both people in a couple feel comfortable and confident about having that type of chat.



△ Building trust and knowledge

As partners build trust in and knowledge of each other, they will learn what they like and enjoy.